

Project Overview: steveditlea.com

Technical reference for maintaining and developing the site

About the Site

This is a personal portfolio website for Steve Ditlea, a journalist and author. The site showcases his work across three content areas — Stories (published articles), Books, and Photos — plus a home page with biographical copy and a contact form. The design is based on the Start Bootstrap "Freelancer" template, customized with Steve's branding.

Tech Stack

The site is built with **Next.js 13.2** using the App Router (app/ directory), **React 18**, **TypeScript 5**, and **Bootstrap 4** (via a large custom CSS file plus React Bootstrap components). Content is managed through **Contentful** as a headless CMS. The contact form sends email via **Nodemailer** through a Gmail SMTP relay. Images are processed with **Sharp**.

Key npm dependencies: contentful (CMS client), nodemailer (email), luxon (date formatting), lodash, react-bootstrap, and sharp.

Project Structure

app/	
(site)/	Route group for the main site layout
layout.tsx	Root layout: nav, header, footer, fonts
page.tsx	Home page (fetches copy from Contentful)
globals.css	Bootstrap 4 + custom theme CSS
components/	
nav.tsx	Top navbar (fixed, dark, hamburger menu)
header.tsx	Masthead with banner image + nav pills
navPills.tsx	Client component: Stories/Books/Photos tabs
divider.tsx	Reusable section divider with icon
contactForm.tsx	Client component: contact form
footer.tsx	Contact form + copyright
stories/	
page.tsx	Server component: fetches articles
article.tsx	Single article row component
books/	
page.tsx	Hardcoded book content
photos/	
page.tsx	Server component: fetches photos
photo.tsx	Single photo card component
api/	
email/	
route.ts	POST handler: sends email via Nodemailer
utils.ts	Contentful client + data-fetching helpers
public/	
pdf/Rock_Stars_Book_V5.pdf	Downloadable book PDF
photos/	Book cover images
scripts/theme.js	jQuery scroll, navbar, floating labels

How the Site Works

Content Sources

Contentful CMS stores articles (stories), photos, home page copy, and the header banner image. Each content type has its own fetcher function in `app/utils.ts`. Pages that use Contentful data are server components with `revalidate = 60`, meaning the ISR cache refreshes every 60 seconds. This lets editorial changes in Contentful appear on the site quickly without a redeploy.

Static files in `public/` — The Books page is entirely hardcoded in JSX. Book cover images and the downloadable PDF live in `public/`. Article thumbnails fall back to a local default icon if no custom thumbnail is uploaded to Contentful.

Routing

The App Router's route group (`site`) wraps all pages in a shared layout with the navbar, header/masthead with nav pills, and footer (which contains the contact form). Pages live at `/` (home), `/stories`, `/books`, and `/photos`. There is also an API route at `/api/email` for the contact form.

Contact Form

The contact form (`contactForm.tsx`) is a client component with a state machine: `PRISTINE` → `EDITING` → `SENDING` → `SUCCESS` or `ERROR`. On submit, it POSTs JSON to `/api/email`, which uses Nodemailer to relay the message through Gmail SMTP. Credentials come from environment variables (`SMTP_USER`, `SMTP_PASSWORD`, `SMTP_RECIPIENT`).

The Gmail SMTP relay requires a Gmail account with 2-Step Verification enabled and an App Password. If the App Password stops working, check that 2-Step Verification is still turned on — Google revokes App Passwords if 2SV is disabled. The free Gmail SMTP limit is 100 emails/day, which is more than sufficient for a brochure site contact form.

Client-Side Interactivity

The nav pills component uses `usePathname()` from Next.js to highlight the active tab. A legacy jQuery script (`theme.js`) handles smooth scrolling, navbar shrink-on-scroll, and floating label animations. Bootstrap's collapse plugin powers the mobile hamburger menu.

Environment Variables

These must be set in the hosting platform's dashboard (or in a local `.env.local` file for development):

Variable	Purpose
<code>CONTENTFUL_SPACE</code>	Contentful space ID
<code>CONTENTFUL_TOKEN</code>	Contentful Content Delivery API access token

SMTP_USER	Gmail address used for sending contact form emails
SMTP_PASSWORD	Gmail App Password (requires 2-Step Verification)
SMTP_RECIPIENT	Email address that receives contact form submissions

None of these are committed to the repo. The .gitignore excludes .env.local files.*

Local Development

To run the site locally:

1. Clone the repo: `git clone <repo-url>`
2. Install dependencies: `npm install` (requires Node.js 18)
3. Create a `.env.local` file in the project root with the five environment variables listed above.
4. Run the development server: `npm run dev`
5. Open `http://localhost:3000` in your browser.

Things to Keep in Mind

The Books page is hardcoded. Unlike Stories and Photos (which pull from Contentful), the Books page has all its content written directly in JSX at `app/(site)/books/page.tsx`. Editing books requires a code change and redeploy. Consider migrating to a Contentful content type if Steve wants to manage this himself.

"Stories" vs. "Articles" naming. The UI says "Stories" but the Contentful content type and all internal code use "articles." A comment in `stories/page.tsx` explains this was a late editorial change.

The CSS file is very large (~5,000+ lines). It bundles the entire Bootstrap 4 framework as raw CSS plus custom overrides. The `package.json` installs Bootstrap 5 but the actual CSS and CDN scripts use Bootstrap 4 — the npm Bootstrap 5 package is effectively unused.

jQuery dependency. `public/scripts/theme.js` uses jQuery for scroll handling and navbar behavior. Since the site uses React, these could be reimplemented as hooks/effects to eliminate the jQuery dependency.

No spam protection on the contact form. The `/api/email` endpoint has no CAPTCHA, honeypot, or rate limiting. Adding basic spam protection (e.g., Cloudflare Turnstile or a honeypot field) is recommended.

TypeScript usage is loose. Several Contentful data accesses use `@ts-ignore` rather than proper types. Contentful supports generated types from the content model, which would make these type-safe.

Next.js version is outdated. The project uses Next.js 13.2.4 with the experimental `appDir` flag. The App Router has been stable since 13.4. Upgrading would remove the experimental flag and bring security patches.

The .gitignore should also exclude plain .env. Currently only `.env*.local` is ignored. Add `.env` to the ignore list as a safety net, especially if the repo becomes public.

The SMTP_USER env var has a code workaround. In the email route, there's a `.replaceAll('\"', '\"')` call that strips quotes from the environment variable value. This

suggests the value was previously wrapped in quotes in the env file. Fix the env file formatting and remove this code.

Contentful Content Management

Contentful is the headless CMS that stores the site's dynamic content. You should have received an invitation to the Contentful space. Once you accept, you'll have access to manage content types and entries. The main content types are:

- **Articles** — shown on the Stories page. Each has a title, publication info, body text, optional thumbnail, and external link.
- **Photos** — shown on the Photos page. Each has an image asset, title, and caption.
- **Home page copy** — biographical text shown on the home page.
- **Header banner** — the masthead image at the top of every page.

Changes made in Contentful appear on the live site within about 60 seconds thanks to ISR (Incremental Static Regeneration) with a 60-second revalidation interval. No redeploy needed.